

20 SQUAD IN IPL SEASON 2

SR WKTS AVG ECON SR

127.2	-	-	-	-
143.47	0	-	25	-
102.87	-	-	-	-
140.9	7	23.42	5.92	23.7
115.64	6	23.66	7.1	20
114.92	11	14.63	7	12.5
132.78	7	34.71	6.94	30
110.9	6	25.16	6.47	23.3
124.05	17	22.94	7.74	17.7
141.3	13	30.3	7.93	22.9
158.49	12	21.33	5.81	22
14.29	18	19.33	6.5	17.8
72.73	6	23.66	6.76	21
47.06	23	18.13	6.98	15.5
123.08	11	27	6.9	23.4

ALL: Average; SR: Strike Rate; WKTS: Wickets; ECON: Economy

due to a new format and a high degree of basic skill in the ranks, particularly with the bat. When the early results rolled their way, they brought momentum, energy, inspiration and a few healthy slices of luck. Now less than two years on, T20 is both the same game and yet a completely novel one.

The advent of the IPL in 2008 with its fattened pay cheques has suddenly turned T20 from 'bubble-gum cricket' into a fairly central part of every professional cricketer's life.

Earlier this year, the Sri Lankan cricket board cancelled its tour of England, once the prize engagement of every team, because their leading players wanted to participate in the IPL. The West Indies stepped in to take the Lankans' place only to have their captain Chris Gayle play an extra IPL game and land at Heathrow, 48 hours before

the first toss of the series. Typically languid, he then said he "wouldn't be so sad" if Test cricket died. More than one player of the current Indian T20 team has privately confessed that 'day cricket' (three, four and five day games) is not their thing.

This March, an Australian Cricketers Association survey revealed that a third of the country's contracted national and state players believed Test cricket would become obsolete in 20 years. A similar survey by the English Professional Cricketers' Association found that more than a third of first-class players would consider early retirement to play in the IPL.

Everyone, it can safely be said, is now trying to work out the best method to succeed in a format of the game once considered simplistic and somewhat brainless. If India are to succeed again, apart from being cool under the hammer, they will need the updated T20 textbook on their fingertips.

In its relatively short life span, T20 cricket has developed its own science and its own strategies. It has changed the grammar of batsmanship, the tactics in bowling and also the players' mindset in the game. 'Session by session' belonged strictly to the Test cricket lexicon and "controlling the middle overs" to the 50-over game. The fundamentals of T20 sound like a crew of armchair analysts gone mad. Sample these: "Singles are the new dot balls" or "*chaar mein chaalis* (40 from four), easy, yaar" or "the best bouncer is a slow bouncer".

But none of it is nonsense. Paul Nixon, former England wicket-keeper and captain of Leicestershire's successful T20 team, says that the international game is picking up the same cues as the county teams did in the early years of T20.



« **RAVI BOPARA**
England's man for all methods succeeded in the IPL and then switched codes, scoring three consecutive Test tons against the West Indies.

» **CHRIS GAYLE**

Scorer of the first century in international T20s (117 off 57 balls) in the 2007 World Cup, the Windies captain loves the short game.



» **A. B. de VILLIERS**

South Africa's crisis man wields a heavy bat and is a key element of a unit expected to challenge India.



» **SOHAIL TANVIR**

Pakistan's strike bowler missed IPL 2 but the maverick left-hander is expected to make an impact in England.



Photographs by REUTERS



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